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From Followers to Founders: Influencer Made Products in Consumer Markets

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Abstract. Influencers are increasingly launching their own products, but it remains unclear what makes consumers actually want to buy them. This study examines how social media signals influence consumer responses to influencer-owned products. Using a conjoint-style experiment in which 208 respondents evaluated 27 simulated posts, random-effects panel models test how engagement metrics, caption tone, and consumer differences affect purchase intent, perceived authenticity, and perceived honesty.

The results show that engagement cues, such as comment volume, significantly increase purchase intent but do not meaningfully change perceptions of authenticity or honesty. Instead, these perceptions are largely shaped by whether consumers have previously purchased influencer products. Model comparisons also indicate that demographic differences improve prediction of purchase intent, while no tested factors explain variation in authenticity or honesty.

Overall, the findings suggest that influencer-owned product success depends more on how posts encourage buying and target the right audience than on short-term attempts to appear authentic.

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1. Introduction

1.1. Overview of influencer marketing

Influencer marketing is when a brand pays or collaborates with a social media creator to promote something to their followers in a way that feels personal or authentic. In brand influencer marketing the way to get an influencer to show off your product follows four simple steps:

1. A brand finds an influencer whose audience matches their target market

2. The influencer creates content featuring the product
3. Followers see the recommendation from someone they trust
4. Which leads to an increase in awareness, trust, and sales for the brand

Influencer marketing has been a topic of concern for marketers since the dark ages of marketing. However, as of 2012, Influencer marketing has become mainstream driven by the rise of image-focused social media platforms. It has been over a decade since then and influencer marketing has exploded and changed in many vast ways. Several research projects have been explored to detail how best to be an influencer and how best to use an influencer for your brand. There is even a break down into the type of influencer they are based on the number of followers they have.

1.2. Research gap

If there are so many projects on this topic you may be asking why is there yet another paper diving deep into the real of realism that is influencer marketing. I give you one simple question in return: Where the gap is in the research? The most notable gap in the various literature about influencer marketing is that little is known about what brings value to an influencer made product. For example, what about Mr.Beast or Logan Paul drives the success or failure of their products. Furthermore, what is it about Shaquille O'Neal that gives him the ability to slap his name or face on a product and it becomes a best seller.

1.3. Research question

The research question we will be studying in this paper is about influencer made products. Specifically, what about an influencer makes their product valuable in the eyes of the consumers? Could it be that the amount of followers or comments establish trust and credibility? or is their something else sprinkled on top, hidden to the naked eye?

2. Theoretical Background and Literature Review

2.1. Influencer Marketing in Prior Research

Prior research on influencer marketing has developed along several complementary streams, including authenticity and reputation dynamics, congruence mechanisms, consumer decision processes, comparative effectiveness of influencers versus celebrities, and technological and demographic moderators of influencer impact.

A first stream examines the dynamic trade-off between authenticity and monetization. The authors develop a dynamic model in which influencers choose an optimal level of authenticity that simultaneously affects current revenue and the growth rate of awareness. The model predicts that

small influencers prioritize authenticity to accelerate follower growth, whereas large influencers optimally shift toward monetization once awareness reaches a sufficiently high level. This finding contrasts with traditional reputation models, which predict that larger actors are more protective of their reputational capital. Extensions further examine celebrities, viral content dynamics, and follower turnover, demonstrating that platform characteristics and external visibility alter optimal endorsement strategies Nistor et al. (2025).

A second stream emphasizes psychological congruence mechanisms. Understanding Influencer Marketing: The Role of Congruence Between Influencers, Products and Consumers grounds influencer effectiveness in balance, cognitive dissonance, and congruity theories. The study highlights the triadic interaction among influencer–follower congruence, influencer–product congruence, and follower–product congruence. Empirical results show that higher congruence strengthens consumer attitudes toward sponsored products, which in turn increases purchase and recommendation intentions. This work clarifies the psychological pathway through which influencer campaigns generate persuasion Zak and Hasprova (2020), Belanche et al. (2021).

A third line of research focuses on influencers within the broader consumer decision-making process. This work systematizes existing knowledge regarding influencer typologies, trust factors, and product category effects. Survey evidence suggests that influencer impact varies substantially across product categories, with stronger influence observed in apparel, cosmetics, and services than in food or electronics. The study also documents that consumers place greater weight on perceived expertise than on attractiveness when evaluating influencer credibility Zak and Hasprova (2020).

Meta-analytic evidence further refines understanding of influencer effectiveness. Findings indicate that social media influencers are more persuasive than brand-only advertisements and are statistically comparable to celebrity endorsers, with perceived credibility acting as a key moderator Lee et al. (2024).

More recent research incorporates demographic heterogeneity, technological change, and advanced modeling techniques. Using mixed methods, including regression analysis and Fuzzy Cognitive Mapping, this work examines how authenticity, transparency, and engagement quality influence consumer trust and purchasing behavior across industries and demographic groups. Results indicate that influencer marketing effects are stronger among younger consumers and in fashion and beauty industries, while excessive promotional activity may induce ad fatigue. The study also integrates technological dimensions such as AI-driven personalization and virtual try-ons, highlighting the evolving digital ecosystem in which influencer marketing operates Migkos et al. (2025).

Taken together, prior research establishes that influencer effectiveness depends on dynamic authenticity management, psychological congruence, credibility perceptions, product category characteristics, and platform-specific dynamics. However, the majority of this literature focuses on paid endorsements rather than influencer-created and owned products. As a result, the mechanisms through which influencer social capital translates into direct product ownership outcomes remain underexplored.

2.2. Observable Influencer Characteristics

There are numerous observable characteristics identified in prior research as important indicators of the value an influencer can bring to a brand. Observable characteristics refer to the visible cues consumers encounter when viewing a social media post. These include audience size (e.g., number of followers), engagement metrics (e.g., likes and comments), posting frequency, content style, and patterns of audience interaction Zak and Hasprova (2020),Migkos et al. (2025).

Because social media environments provide limited information and rapid consumption, consumers rely on these visible signals as heuristic cues when forming judgments about an influencer. Rather than conducting deep evaluations, consumers often use engagement metrics and presentation style to infer broader qualities such as credibility, expertise, and social approval. Importantly, these surface-level indicators shape deeper perceptions of the influencer, including whether the influencer is trustworthy, honest, and authentic. Thus, observable characteristics function as the foundation upon which more complex relational evaluations are formed Belanche et al. (2021), Lee et al. (2024).

2.3. Trust, Honesty, and Authenticity

Observable characteristics play a critical role in shaping consumer perceptions of both the influencer and the product being promoted. Beyond the content of the message itself, visible signals such as engagement metrics, audience size, and presentation style influence how consumers interpret the credibility of the promotion. For influencer-created products in particular, the influencer must persuade consumers that the product effectively fulfills a meaningful need and provides genuine value Belanche et al. (2021), Lee et al. (2024), Zak and Hasprova (2020).

Influencers often attempt to accomplish this by demonstrating product usage scenarios and describing how the product has improved their own lives. However, consumers do not rely solely on these claims. Instead, they evaluate underlying qualities of the influencer to determine whether the promotional message should be believed Migkos et al. (2025), Belanche et al. (2021), Nistor et al. (2025).

Specifically, consumers assess:

- **Trustworthiness:** The extent to which the influencer is perceived as reliable and dependable. Much like reviews the engagement on a post is important here. The number of Comments and likes can make or break a consumer's willingness to purchase Lee et al. (2024), Zak and Hasprova (2020), Migkos et al. (2025).
- **Honesty:** The degree to which the influencer appears truthful and transparent in their communication. This often comes across in the posts commentary wether written or spoken. The way the influencer depicts the product is important Migkos et al. (2025), Nistor et al. (2025).
- **Authenticity:** The extent to which the influencer presents themselves as genuine rather than purely commercial or promotional. The words the influencer uses to describe the product feel real and not another commercial Nistor et al. (2025), Migkos et al. (2025).

Together, these perceptions shape consumer responses to influencer-created products and influence purchase intentions.

3. Methodology

3.1. Likert Scale Measures

Given the limited research on influencer-created products (as opposed to influencer endorsements), this study adapts established influencer marketing constructs to the context of influencer-owned brands. Respondents evaluated a simulated social media post using Likert-scale measures.

Participants were shown a social media post featuring an influencer promoting their own product. Elements of the post varied across conditions, including engagement metrics (number of likes and comments) and caption tone (formal versus casual). After viewing the post, respondents indicated their level of agreement with a series of statements using seven-point Likert scales ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree.

The Likert items were designed to measure the following constructs:

- **Purchase Intention:** The extent to which the respondent would consider trying or buying the featured product.
- **Perceived Honesty:** The degree to which the influencer is viewed as truthful and transparent in promoting the product.
- **Perceived Authenticity:** The extent to which the influencer appears genuine rather than purely promotional.

Engagement metrics (likes and comments) were manipulated to reflect realistic but varying levels of audience interaction. Caption language was also manipulated to reflect either a more formal

product introduction or a more casual, conversational tone. These variations allow for examination of how presentation style and visible engagement influence consumer perceptions of influencer-created products.

3.2. Survey Measures

3.2.1. Demographic Information Demographic information was gathered as well. These variables were gathered to see the effect of varying demographic information on the mega influencers value. The demographic variables have been broken up into two different groups: Behavioral demographics and Socio-Demographics. The demographic variables are listed below:

- **Behavioral Demographics:**
  - **Platform Usage:** Social media platforms the respondent reports using (e.g., YouTube, Facebook, Instagram).
  - **Familiar Influencers:** A list of prominent influencers the respondent indicates being familiar with (e.g., MrBeast, Logan Paul, Stephen Curry).
  - **Frequency of Usage:** How often the respondent uses social media, ranging from daily to never.
  - **Purchased Influencer Products:** Whether the respondent has purchased a product because it was recommended or promoted by an influencer.
- **Socio-Demographics:**
  - **Education Level:** The highest level of education completed by the respondent.
  - **Race:** The racial identity self-reported by the respondent.
  - **Age:** The respondent's age, categorized into ten-year intervals.
  - **Gender:** The gender identity self-reported by the respondent.
  - **Employment Status:** The respondent's employment status within the past three months.
  - **Marital Status:** The respondent's current marital status.
  - **Income Level:** The respondent's self-reported income category.

3.3. Stimulus Design: Social Media Post

To examine how observable characteristics influence consumer perceptions, respondents were shown a simulated social media post in which an influencer promoted their own product. The post was designed to closely resemble a typical Instagram-style promotional upload in order to enhance realism and external validity.

Each post contained the following elements:

- A product image positioned at the top of the post
- The influencer's username and profile identifier
- Engagement metrics (number of likes and comments)
- A written caption describing the product

Two key elements of the post were experimentally varied across conditions: (1) engagement metrics (likes and comments), and (2) caption tone (formal versus casual language).

Engagement metrics were manipulated to reflect realistic but varying levels of audience interaction. Caption tone was adjusted to reflect either a structured, product-focused description (formal condition) or a conversational, personality-driven message (casual condition). To illustrate the experimental manipulation, representative examples of both caption conditions are presented below.

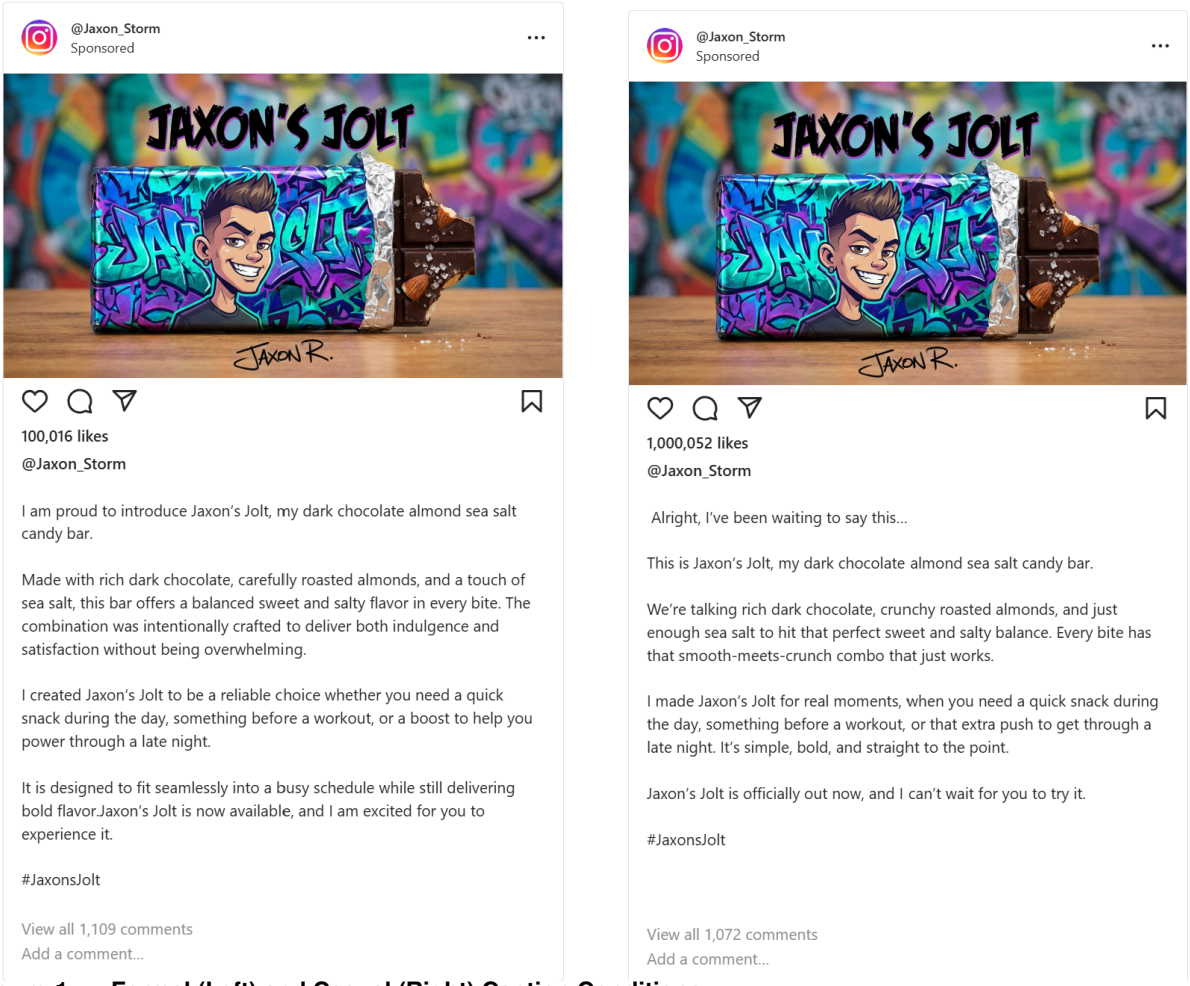

Figure 1 Formal (Left) and Casual (Right) Caption Conditions

Aside from caption tone and engagement metrics, all other elements of the post were held constant across conditions. The product image, influencer identity, layout, hashtags, and overall

visual structure remained identical. This ensured that any differences in respondent evaluations could be attributed to the manipulated variables rather than unrelated visual differences.

After viewing the post, respondents evaluated the influencer and product using seven-point Likert scale measures assessing trustworthiness, honesty, authenticity, and purchase intention.

3.4. Mathematical Models

The study adopts a panel linear model (PLM) framework to formalize the relationships between observable influencer post characteristics, consumer demographics, and the three outcome measures: Purchase Intent (Y_{PI}), Perceived Honesty (Y_{PH}), and Perceived Authenticity (Y_{PA}). Because each respondent evaluated multiple conjoint scenarios, the data have a repeated-measures structure in which individual-level unobserved heterogeneity must be accounted for. A random-effects specification was chosen over fixed effects to allow estimation of time-invariant respondent-level predictors (demographics, platform usage, and influencer familiarity), which would otherwise be absorbed by individual fixed effects.

The baseline model for each outcome Y_{it} is:

$$Y_{it} \;=\; \alpha + \mathbf{x}_{it}^{\top}\boldsymbol{\beta} + \mathbf{z}_{i}^{\top}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + u_i + \varepsilon_{it}, \tag{1}$$

where $i = 1, \ldots, 208$ indexes respondents, $t = 1, \ldots, 27$ indexes conjoint scenarios, $\mathbf{x}_{it}$ is the vector of within-respondent conjoint attributes that vary across scenarios (number of comments, number of likes, writing style, and influencer tier), $\mathbf{z}_i$ is the vector of between-respondent characteristics that are constant within a respondent (age, gender, income, education, employment status, marital status, race, social media platform membership, influencer interaction frequency, social media use frequency, prior influencer product purchase, and known-influencer familiarity flags), $u_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_u^2)$ is the individual random effect capturing stable, unobserved consumer heterogeneity, and $\varepsilon_{it} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_\varepsilon^2)$ is the idiosyncratic error. The composite error is $v_{it} = u_i + \varepsilon_{it}$, and the intraclass correlation $\rho = \sigma_u^2/(\sigma_u^2 + \sigma_\varepsilon^2)$ captures the proportion of total variance attributable to persistent individual differences. Estimated values of ρ across the three outcomes ranged from 0.53 to 0.68, confirming that stable respondent heterogeneity dominates within-respondent scenario variation, and motivating the random-effects structure.

The conjoint attributes are deviation-coded. Writing style is coded +1 (casual) and 0 (formal); number of comments and number of likes are each coded 0 (low) and +1 (high); influencer type is a three-level factor coded −1 (Jaxson), 0 (Bella), and +1 (Max). This coding scheme allows the coefficients on $\mathbf{x}_{it}$ to be interpreted as deviations from the grand mean of each attribute.

To examine how consumer characteristics moderate the effect of post characteristics on each outcome, the baseline model in Equation 1 is extended with two-way interaction terms between conjoint attributes and each moderator set. Three extended model specifications are estimated per outcome:

Model A Demographics adds all pairwise interactions between the four conjoint attributes and age, gender, and income:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \mathbf{x}_{it}^{\top}\boldsymbol{\beta} + \mathbf{z}_i^{\top}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + (\mathbf{x}_{it} \otimes \mathbf{d}_i)^{\top}\boldsymbol{\delta} + u_i + \varepsilon_{it}, \tag{2}$$

where $\mathbf{d}_i$ contains the demographic moderators and $\otimes$ denotes the column-wise Kronecker product of the conjoint and moderator vectors, yielding approximately 148 estimable coefficients.

Model B Social Media Platforms replaces $\mathbf{d}_i$ with a vector of seven binary platform membership indicators (Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, X/Twitter, YouTube, Twitch, Facebook), yielding approximately 113 estimable coefficients.

Model C Known Influencers replaces $\mathbf{d}_i$ with nine binary familiarity indicators for Shaquille O'Neal, Kylie Jenner, MrBeast, Logan Paul, Stephen Curry, Taylor Swift, Ryan Reynolds, KSI, and Charli D'Amelio, yielding approximately 123 estimable coefficients.

Across all models, variance components are estimated using the Swamy–Arora transformation, and the quasi-demeaning parameter θ is computed as

$$\theta = 1 - \frac{\sigma_\varepsilon}{\sqrt{T\sigma_u^2 + \sigma_\varepsilon^2}}, \tag{3}$$

where $T = 27$ is the number of time periods (scenarios) per respondent. Values of $\hat{\theta}$ in the present models ranged from 0.823 to 0.868, indicating that the quasi-demeaning transformation removed a large share of the between-respondent variation and that inference is based primarily on within-person scenario-level variation.

3.5. Statistical and Analytical Methods

Data preparation. Raw survey responses were loaded from a CSV export ($n_{\text{raw}} = 437$ respondents). After removing respondents who were screened out of the survey there were 244 respondents left. A straight-lining check was applied: respondents whose ratings showed zero standard deviation on at least one of the three outcome scales across all scenarios were flagged as potential non-engagers and removed ($n_{\text{removed}} = 24$), yielding 218 respondents. After listwise deletion of rows

with any missing value on analysis variables, the final analytic sample comprised $n = 208$ respondents, producing a balanced panel of $N = 5{,}616$ observations (208×27). All conjoint attributes were converted to factors prior to modeling, with influencer tier releveled to the mid-tier condition as reference.

Panel estimation. All models were estimated using the `plm` package (v2.x) in R. The Swamy–Arora random-effects estimator was used throughout, as it is consistent and efficient when the individual-level random effects are uncorrelated with the regressors an assumption supported by the between-respondent nature of the demographic moderators, which were not experimentally assigned. Each of the twelve models was fit separately for each outcome–moderator combination.

Hypothesis testing. Significance of individual coefficients was assessed using two-tailed z-tests at the $\alpha = .05$ level, with marginal significance noted at $\alpha = .10$. Overall model fit was evaluated using the Wald chi-square statistic on all slope coefficients. Because the extended models include a large number of interaction terms relative to the sample size, adjusted R^2 is reported alongside unadjusted R^2 to penalize model complexity. Degrees of freedom for each model reflect the number of estimable coefficients after dropping aliased terms due to perfect multicollinearity (typically one platform dummy per model).

Model comparison via RMSE. To compare predictive performance across specifications, root mean squared error (RMSE) was computed for each model as

$$\text{RMSE} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \sum_{t=1}^{T} \hat{\varepsilon}_{it}^2}, \tag{4}$$

where $\hat{\varepsilon}_{it}$ are the model residuals. RMSE provides a scale-interpretable summary of fit on the original seven-point Likert scale and allows direct comparison across the four model specifications (baseline plus Models A, B, and C) for each outcome.

Covariate coding. All socio-demographic and behavioral covariates were dummy-coded from multi-select survey responses. Platform membership and influencer familiarity were extracted as binary indicators via string detection on concatenated multi-select fields, with each indicator equal to one if the respondent selected that platform or influencer and zero otherwise. Influencer interaction frequency and social media use frequency were included as ordered categorical variables with the most frequent category serving as the reference in each case. Prior influencer product purchase was coded as a binary indicator (1 = yes, 0 = no).

Software. All analyses were conducted in R (version 4.3.x) using the `plm`, `tidyverse`, and `car` packages. Quarto (v1.6) was used for reproducible reporting of model output.

4. Results

All results are drawn from nine exploratory panel linear models (PLMs) estimated with Swamy–Arora random effects on a balanced panel of $n = 208$ respondents across $T = 27$ conjoint scenarios ($N = 5{,}616$ observations). listwise deletion, yielding the final 208-respondent analytic sample. Each outcome (*Purchase Intent*, *Perceived Authenticity*, and *Perceived Honesty*) was modeled three times: Model A interacted the conjoint attributes with demographic moderators (age, gender, income; ≈148 coefficients); Model B interacted them with social media platform membership (≈113 coefficients); and Model C interacted them with familiarity with nine named influencers (≈123 coefficients). The conjoint attributes in all models are: number of comments (low vs. high), number of likes (low vs. high), writing style (formal vs. casual), and influencer tier (Max, Bella, or Jaxon).

4.1. Purchase Intent

4.1.1. Significant Positive Effects Across all three Purchase Intent models the conjoint attributes themselves were the dominant and consistent drivers of purchase intent. Higher comment counts produced a strong positive effect on purchase intent in Model A ($\hat{\beta} = 0.908$, $p < .001$), and this pattern persisted in Model C ($p = .001$), confirming that visible audience engagement raises willingness to buy. Higher like counts likewise increased purchase intent in Model A ($\hat{\beta} = 0.357$, $p = .012$). A casual writing style showed a consistent *negative* main effect ($\hat{\beta} = -1.176$, $p < .001$ in Model A), indicating that the formal caption condition drove higher purchase intent on average; however, several positive interactions involving writing style are reported below.

Respondents who had previously purchased an influencer product scored meaningfully higher on purchase intent across all three models ($p = .023$ in Model A; $p = .047$ in Model C), suggesting prior behavior is a reliable positive predictor. Among demographic controls, employed respondents whether working full-time, part-time, or unemployed and actively seeking work reported higher purchase intent than the reference category in Models A and C (all $p < .05$). Widowed respondents also showed a significant positive offset ($p = .029$ in Model A). Facebook usage was a significant positive predictor in Model A ($\hat{\beta} = 0.575$, $p = .026$).

Among the conjoint-by-demographic interactions in Model A, the writing-style effect was amplified for older age groups: the casual-versus-formal contrast was reversed and positively significant for 55–64-year-olds ($p < .001$) and for respondents aged 65 and older ($p < .001$), meaning older

consumers responded more positively to a casual caption tone. Higher income groups showed broad positive interactions with influencer tier, with the interaction between the low-tier influencer condition and income being significant and positive for nearly every income bracket (all $p < .01$). Among influencer-familiarity interactions in Model C, familiarity with Kylie Jenner ($p = .003$), MrBeast ($p = .024$), and several writing-style interactions were significantly positive.

4.1.2. Significant Negative Effects The formal caption condition, when combined with a low-tier influencer profile, consistently dampened purchase intent. The interaction of high comment count with the low-tier influencer produced a significant negative coefficient in Model A ($\hat{\beta} = -0.251$, $p = .006$). Similarly, the comments-by-likes interaction was negative ($\hat{\beta} = -0.173$, $p = .013$), indicating that simultaneous high engagement on both metrics did not compound positively for purchase intent.

Among demographic interactions in Model A, higher comment counts negatively moderated purchase intent for 25–34-year-olds ($p < .001$) and 35–44-year-olds ($p < .001$), and higher like counts negatively moderated purchase intent for 25–34-year-olds ($p < .001$), 45–54-year-olds ($p < .001$), and respondents aged 65 and older ($p < .001$). Male respondents showed a significant negative interaction with the low-tier influencer ($p < .001$). High comment counts produced broad negative interactions across income groups in Model A, with all tested income brackets showing significant negative coefficients (all $p < .001$ or better).

In Model C, familiarity with Logan Paul ($p = .001$) and Ryan Reynolds ($p = .009$) was associated with lower purchase intent, suggesting that awareness of these particular influencers reduces rather than increases conversion for the Jaxon's Jolt stimulus.

4.1.3. Non-Significant Effects Demographic main effects for age, gender, race, education level, marital status, social media use frequency, influencer interaction frequency, and platform usage were largely non-significant across all three Purchase Intent models. In Model B, which interacted conjoint attributes with platform membership, none of the platform interaction terms reached significance, and the overall model fit was considerably weaker ($R^2 = 0.139$) than Model A ($R^2 = 0.245$). Model C achieved an R^2 of 0.153.

4.2. Perceived Authenticity

4.2.1. Significant Positive Effects Perceived authenticity proved the most resistant outcome to prediction by observable post characteristics. Across all three models, none of the four conjoint main effects comments, likes, writing style, or influencer tier reached conventional significance.

The only consistent positive predictor was prior influencer product purchase: respondents who had previously bought an influencer product rated the stimulus influencer as more authentic (Model A: $p = .010$; Model B: $p = .006$; Model C: $p = .013$). Marginal positive associations were observed for lower-income respondents ("Less than $25,000") in Models A and C ($p \approx .07$) and for respondents familiar with Stephen Curry in Model C ($p = .014$).

4.2.2. Significant Negative Effects No conjoint attribute or interaction term produced a significant negative effect on perceived authenticity in any of the three models. The absence of significant negative predictors, combined with the absence of significant positive predictors among the stimulus manipulations, points to a finding of genuine null structure: the experimental post characteristics tested in this study do not meaningfully alter consumers' judgments of influencer authenticity.

4.2.3. Non-Significant Effects Model A returned an R^2 of 0.016 ($p = 1.000$ for the overall chi-square test), Model B an R^2 of 0.017 ($p = .920$), and Model C an R^2 of 0.015 ($p = .998$). All models performed at or below chance in terms of explained variance, and no interaction involving comments, likes, writing style, or influencer tier with any demographic, platform, or influencer-familiarity moderator reached significance. Race, education, employment status, marital status, social media use frequency, and influencer interaction frequency were uniformly non-significant. The RMSE for all three Perceived Authenticity models was approximately 1.05, identical to the original interaction model, confirming that adding demographic, platform, or influencer-familiarity interactions provides no predictive improvement for this outcome.

4.3. Perceived Honesty

4.3.1. Significant Positive Effects Like perceived authenticity, perceived honesty showed little sensitivity to the experimentally manipulated post characteristics. Prior influencer product purchase was the only consistent significant predictor, showing a positive association in Model A ($p = .009$) and Model C ($p = .008$). Among influencer familiarity terms in Model A, knowing MrBeast ($p = .034$) and Stephen Curry ($p = .028$) were associated with marginally higher honesty ratings. At the demographic level, lower income ("Less than $25,000") showed a marginal positive association in Model C ($p = .020$), and income of $50,000–$74,999 showed a marginal positive association in Model A ($p = .047$).

4.3.2. Significant Negative Effects Familiarity with Logan Paul was associated with lower perceived honesty ratings in Model A ($p = .027$) and Model C ($p = .021$), consistent with the purchase intent results and suggesting that Logan Paul's public reputation carries a negative credibility signal that suppresses honesty assessments regardless of post content. Ryan Reynolds familiarity was also a significant negative predictor in Model C ($p = .040$). No conjoint main effect or conjoint interaction term reached significance for honesty in any model.

4.3.3. Non-Significant Effects Model A for Perceived Honesty produced an R^2 of 0.014 ($p = 1.000$), Model B an R^2 of 0.018 ($p = .785$), and Model C an R^2 of 0.014 ($p = 1.000$). As with perceived authenticity, all three models failed to improve on chance, and the overall chi-square tests were non-significant. The RMSE across all three models ranged from 0.951 to 0.956, with Model C (known influencers) producing the marginal best fit and Model B (platforms) the marginal worst.

4.4. RMSE Model Comparison

Table 1 summarizes the root mean squared error for all twelve models (three outcomes × four model specifications, including the original conjoint-only interaction model).

Table 1 RMSE Comparison Across Outcomes and Model Specifications

Outcome	Model	RMSE
Purchase Intent	Model A: Demographics	0.902
Purchase Intent	Model C: Known Influencers	0.956
Purchase Intent	Model B: Platforms	0.968
Purchase Intent	Original Interaction	1.030
Perceived Honesty	Model C: Known Influencers	0.951
Perceived Honesty	Model A: Demographics	0.952
Perceived Honesty	Model B: Platforms	0.955
Perceived Honesty	Original Interaction	0.956
Perceived Authenticity	Model C: Known Influencers	1.050
Perceived Authenticity	Model A: Demographics	1.050
Perceived Authenticity	Model B: Platforms	1.050
Perceived Authenticity	Original Interaction	1.050

The RMSE comparison reveals a clear hierarchy across outcomes. For Purchase Intent, Model A (demographics) provided the best fit, reducing RMSE from 1.030 in the original model to 0.902

the largest improvement observed across all comparisons. This improvement corresponds to the many significant demographic and income-level interactions documented above, particularly the strong moderating role of income on comment and like sensitivity and the age-based reversal of the writing-style effect. For Perceived Honesty, all four specifications performed nearly identically (RMSE range: 0.951–0.956), with known-influencer familiarity (Model C) providing a trivially smaller residual. For Perceived Authenticity, all four models produced identical RMSE values of approximately 1.05, indicating that no moderator set tested here explains any meaningful variance in authenticity judgments beyond baseline individual differences.

Taken together, the results indicate that Purchase Intent is sensitive to both the observable post characteristics (especially comment volume, like volume, and caption tone) and to demographic and influencer-familiarity moderators, while Perceived Honesty and Perceived Authenticity are driven primarily by individual-level predispositions most notably, prior experience purchasing influencer products rather than by the characteristics of the post itself.

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical Contributions

This study makes several contributions to the influencer marketing literature by shifting the unit of analysis from paid brand endorsements to influencer-owned products. Prior research has extensively examined how observable influencer characteristics shape consumer attitudes toward sponsored content (Belanche et al. 2021, Lee et al. 2024, Migkos et al. 2025, Nistor et al. 2025, Zak and Hasprova 2020), but the mechanisms through which those same signals operate when the influencer is the product creator and owner have remained largely unexamined. The present findings extend this literature in three meaningful ways.

First, the results confirm that engagement metrics are not neutral signals. High comment volume significantly increased purchase intent ($\hat{\beta} = 0.908$, $p < .001$), while the simultaneous presence of high comments and high likes produced a negative interaction effect ($p = .013$), suggesting that consumers do not simply aggregate engagement cues additively. This finding is consistent with theoretical accounts of social proof that treat engagement as a credibility heuristic (Lee et al. 2024), but adds nuance by showing that the credibility signal becomes noisy when multiple engagement dimensions peak simultaneously. The implication for theory is that engagement quality, not just quantity, matters for influencer-owned products in ways that differ from the endorsement context.

Second, the near-complete null findings for Perceived Honesty and Perceived Authenticity are theoretically meaningful. Prior work positions authenticity as the central mediating variable through

which influencer characteristics convert to consumer outcomes (Nistor et al. 2025, Migkos et al. 2025). The present study finds that none of the experimentally manipulated post characteristics engagement volume, caption tone, or influencer tier moved authenticity ratings in any systematic direction (all model $R^2 < 0.02$, RMSE ≈ 1.05 across all specifications). This suggests that authenticity perceptions for influencer-owned products are formed prior to post exposure and are anchored in stable individual-level dispositions rather than being responsive to observable content signals. This is consistent with the dynamic authenticity model of Nistor et al. (2025), who argue that authenticity is a reputation stock accumulated over time, but extends that argument to the product ownership context by showing that short-term post-level signals cannot meaningfully move that stock within a single exposure.

Third, the strong moderating role of income on comment and like sensitivity for purchase intent, and the complete absence of such moderation for authenticity and honesty, suggests that economic access and purchasing capacity interact with engagement heuristics in ways that are outcome-specific. Consumers in lower income brackets showed attenuated sensitivity to high comment counts, while higher-income consumers showed larger negative reactions to simultaneous high engagement. This pattern is consistent with research on elaboration likelihood and consumer skepticism (Zak and Hasprova 2020), and points to the need for influencer product research to model demographic heterogeneity rather than treating consumer response as uniform.

5.2. Managerial Implications

The findings offer practical guidance for influencers planning to launch or grow their own product lines, as well as for managers and investors evaluating influencer brand ventures.

For influencers, the results suggest that caption tone is consequential for purchase intent in ways that interact with audience age. A formal, product-focused caption drove higher purchase intent on average, but this effect reversed for older consumer segments (55 and above), who responded more positively to a casual, conversational tone. Influencers whose audiences skew older should therefore adopt a more conversational promotional voice, while those with younger audiences may benefit from a more structured, feature-oriented presentation. Importantly, neither caption style moved authenticity or honesty perceptions, meaning tone choices are a purchase conversion lever rather than a reputation-management tool.

The dominance of prior purchase behavior as a predictor across all three outcomes underscores that the first sale is the hardest. Consumers who had already purchased an influencer product rated the stimulus influencer as more authentic, more honest, and more worth buying from again.

Influencers entering the product space should therefore invest heavily in acquisition strategies for first-time buyers such as introductory pricing, sampling, or exclusive early-access offers with the expectation that post-purchase loyalty effects will amplify organic conversion over time.

For managers and brand investors, the RMSE comparison offers a diagnostic tool. The substantial improvement in purchase intent prediction achieved by the demographic interaction model (RMSE reduced from 1.030 to 0.902) relative to the platform and known-influencer models confirms that audience demographics are more actionable segmentation variables than platform membership or influencer familiarity alone when forecasting sales potential for an influencer-owned product. Marketing budgets and targeting strategies for influencer product launches should therefore prioritize demographic precision over platform reach.

Finally, the finding that familiarity with Logan Paul consistently suppressed both purchase intent and perceived honesty ratings, while familiarity with Kylie Jenner and Stephen Curry had positive associations, reinforces the importance of influencer reputation management. Not all name recognition is equivalent. Influencer product ventures carry the full weight of the influencer's existing public persona, and negative reputational signals are not neutralized by post-level content choices.

5.3. Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the present findings. The most prominent is that the conjoint stimulus featured a single product category: a dark chocolate almond sea salt candy bar (Jaxon's Jolt). Consumer responses to influencer-owned products are likely to vary substantially across product categories. Fashion and apparel, for example, may involve higher levels of identity expression and congruence sensitivity (Belanche et al. 2021), while food and snack products may activate different trust and health-related heuristics than beauty or lifestyle goods. Determining the cross-category boundary conditions of the present findings for instance, whether a fashion influencer who launches a clothing line elicits different authenticity dynamics than a food creator who launches a snack brand is an important direction for future research.

A second limitation concerns external validity. The influencer stimulus like Jaxon's Jolt, promoted by the fictional @Jaxon_Storm account was constructed to maximize experimental control but does not capture the full richness of real-world influencer content, including video, Stories, long-form commentary, and multi-platform presence. Responses to a simulated static Instagram-style post may underestimate the persuasive depth of actual influencer content ecosystems, and replication with real influencer accounts and live product launches is warranted.

Finally, the conjoint design varied four attributes simultaneously (comments, likes, writing style, and influencer tier), which, while common in conjoint analysis, constrains the granularity with which attribute-level effects can be estimated when interactions are also modeled. Future designs might isolate writing style and engagement metrics across larger attribute ranges to better characterize the functional form of those relationships.

6. Conclusion

The From Followers to Founders project set out to answer a deceptively simple question: what is it about an influencer that makes consumers want to buy their product? The answer, it turns out, is more nuanced than follower counts or like tallies alone can explain. Across 208 respondents and 5,616 conjoint evaluations, this study found that the observable characteristics of an influencer's promotional post engagement volume, caption tone, and influencer tier significantly shaped purchase intent, but left perceptions of honesty and authenticity almost entirely unmoved. Authenticity, it appears, is not something a single post can manufacture; it is a reputation that consumers bring with them to the screen.

The most actionable finding is also the most human one: The way influencers communicate to their possible consumers matters. Influencers must determine who their audience is and communicate the value of their product in the way their audience will understand.

For the broader influencer marketing literature, this project contributes a framework for studying influencers not as endorsers but as founders a role in which their social capital must convert not just into attention, but into sustained commercial outcomes. The shift from sponsored post to owned product is more than a business model change; it is a different kind of trust transaction, one that this research has only begun to map. Future work should extend the analysis across product categories, platforms, and influencer types to determine where and for whom influencer-owned products can most reliably translate follower loyalty into market success.

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